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Joe Bushkin

Pianist Joe Bushkin was born in New York City on November 7, 1916. He started performing professionally in 1932 with Frank LaMarr at the Roseland Ballroom and since then has played with virtually all the great jazz stars including Louis Armstrong, Eddie Condon and Billie Holiday. Joe is known mostly for his distinctive piano work but also made a mark as a trumpeter and songwriter. His wealth of knowledge about jazz is legendary and he has been a guest on Marian McPartland's "Piano Jazz" series.

Joe was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 15, 1999, by Monk Rowe, director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Los Angeles filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I'm very, very pleased to have Joe Bushkin as my guest today, a fellow who's been around the world as well as to Hamilton College. So welcome.

JB: Right. It's good to see you, Monk.

MR: You know I look at your list of people you've played with, and I almost have to look at who you haven't played with as opposed —

JB: Yeah I think that makes more sense. When you talk about who I haven't played with as a start, back in 1932 I was about 15-1/2 and playing with a band at the Roseland Ballroom, Frank LaMarr and his stock arrangement orchestra which drove me nuts. And that started it all off. Actually I was playing trumpet and then I substituted for a piano player and then just stayed at the piano, as opposed to playing second trumpet under an out of tune trumpet lead all night. And it doesn't take long for one to get tuned into their survival instinct. It starts with day one as we know.

MR: Speaking of out of tune, you must have encountered a few pianos along the way that were fairly out of tune.

JB: Oh absolutely. As a matter of fact I became a roller coaster expert with the Berigan band and then Tommy Dorsey band I was with, whenever we played all the ballrooms at the various amusement parks doing one nighters, if a piano was a half a tone off at least I could transpose a little bit. But sometimes it was a quarter of a tone off and then I must say Tommy was most pleasant about it. He says "take off Joe, the roller coaster's waiting for you." And I became a champ at that. But let's see where were we?

MR: Well how did you learn your piano skills? Were you mostly self taught?

JB: No I studied, when I was about nine or ten I studied with a girl who lived up on the third floor of an apartment building we lived in, and I enjoyed the 45 minutes or an hour once a week and learned to play the "Minuet in G" like all the kids, and the scales or whatever.

And then there was a chap named Cosiff, who was the owner of the building, and back in those days, it will probably sound very strange to you but I might as well continue, where the old guy would come around every week and collect his rent. It was the only way he was going to be sure he got it every week. And the old guy wasn't feeling well or whatever, and his son came around and it turned out that his son had studied with Joseph Levine over in Paris or wherever, yeah I guess it was Paris, and one of the great concert pianists. And I was in the other room playing the "Minuet in G" and he was curious about me and he had me go in the kitchen, and he'd hit a note and I'd tell him what note it was. He'd hit two notes and I had perfect pitch.

MR: You had perfect pitch, huh?

JB: Yeah, which I wasn't aware of. And like all kids of that particular age, I couldn't resist scooting around on a bicycle and getting both arms put in a cast and had started the trumpet playing of course, I switched over. But anyway, that was a start, and I've got to tell you, when I think of what's going on in our world in the 90's economically, we were happy to get three dollars a night for playing a Polish paperhanger ball or something. A wallpaper hanger.

MR: How did your folks feel about your progression into music and when it looked like it was going to be a career?

JB: Oh they were wonderful with me and my dad was, we lived in the most patriarch society you could possibly imagine which would take a great imagination to come up with, back in those days. I was 82 years old this last year so I'm talking about 70 years ago, and my dad was very, very musically inclined and he just loved the idea of me doing music. My brother studied violin but he wound up playing in the NYU Symphony Orchestra or whatever when he was going to college. He was not lucky I'd say to be born with a natural talent.

MR: You mentioned playing stock arrangements with that first band. These were things that just could be purchased by any band?

JB: Right.

MR: They weren't specifically written for that particular group.

JB: Right exactly. They were always written for I believe five brass and four saxophones and a rhythm section. And they were the tunes that were coming out on Broadway or films and so forth. In any case, nowadays the kids get a terrific break because actually if a guy has a band he's in the position to buy Billy May's arrangements and Billy Byers' and all of the best, Sy Oliver and, I mean —

MR: The great writers.

JB: All of the great arrangements that they did are available. And if you are with the right band you'll be playing those kind of arrangements.

MR: And you played mostly for dancing at these ballrooms?

JB: Yeah it was back in the 30's, the early 30's, and into the swing era. And I played intermission piano at Kelly's Stables when the Coleman Hawkins Quartet was there, and I was at the Embers. I could go on endlessly, where — we opened the Embers in New York which became the hot jazz venue and we were there for nine weeks and believe it or not I was there with Milt Hinton, Buck Clayton, Jo Jones on drums, that was the quartet, and Art Tatum was there appearing.

MR: Did you guys play one set?

JB: Yeah, we just spelled one another, and it was hard work actually because you played four or five shows a night from 9:30 to 4 in the morning. And as many times, Art would call me and ask me to do his first set for him because he wasn't feeling up to it. And I'd be happy to do it. You know, when you're a young cat and you've got a lot of energy, and also, a great love for what I was doing, which was the biggest break of all. The percentage of people in the world who go to work every day and really love what they do, is very, very small. I can't even think of it mathematically, it's way down there.

MR: You made a statement I think about Art Tatum, that he was a surgeon, what he did?

JB: Yeah. I guess so, yeah. I was in a different racket. I was a lawyer and he was a surgeon. I couldn't — whereas Johnny Smith played with us a few weeks at a time, he's on one of the CD's that you have here on "The Road to Oslo" with Bing Crosby, the Alliance Jazz, and Johnny Smith, Jake Hanna and Milt Hinton and myself, we were with Bing on tour. I loved being with him. We were never presented more beautifully and he just was a jazz aficionado. And I've done a couple of things for the Sinatra, at Hofstra University, you know that's all been going on. And I was with Tommy Dorsey's band when Frank was a boy singer for about two years. And I loved Frank. He was saying one of the things he missed with the Dorsey band was my piano playing, and that was a great compliment. And then Frank recorded some material for me. In fact he got "Hot Time in the Town of Berlin" over to Bing when there was a musician's strike on for about two years. I don't know, you might not recall that.

MR: That's right. The musician's union wouldn't allow any recording.

JB: Right. In '43 or whatever, '42, '43. I was a band leader in Douglas, Arizona in the Air Corps and I was up in L.A. picking up some dance band equipment which the government, it wasn't G.I. equipment obviously. And I picked up some mutes and derbies and some dance band stands for my jazz band, amongst the 45 or 50 musicians we had in the military band. It was the 410th Air Corps Band, and it was in Douglas,

Arizona, and they built a brand new air field for P-38 pilots who trained A-20's, which was a two-seater, with the exact confirmation of a P-38. And when you think about it they were graduating maybe five or six thousand cadets every six, seven weeks.

MR: Wow. And these were young fellows, right?

JB: All young fellows, yeah.

MR: Right out of high school.

JB: Right and all being sent out — there sure was a world war on at the time. I don't even realize that there were some other wars that went on, Korea and Vietnam. Guys talk about being in the Army, later on, I wonder. Somehow or other when you're not in the service you don't think about it. Same old story.

MR: You got sent overseas yourself, right?

JB: Yeah, well I was over on the Marianas and when I was at Douglas I ran into Dave Rose, who was the musician director for a new show which was going to be called "Winged Victory," that Morris Hart wrote, and Swifty Lazar the agent, he was a captain in the show in the Air Corps. And I was delighted to be an assistant conductor to Dave and I'd conducted this big 80 piece orchestra or whatever, a Wednesday matinee and a Saturday. It was easy because Dave had already straightened it out. And I figured out very early in life in order to get the attention of that many men, slow it down occasionally and go a little faster occasionally, otherwise they're not going to even look up. Same old story.

MR: Good point. That's a very good point.

JB: Oh absolutely.

MR: You have to let them know that you're up there.

JB: Oh for sure.

MR: And amongst the technical musicians, it's a far cry from the jazz field you know. We just ran into Bill Berry down in the lobby of the hotel, I got such a kick out of seeing Bill. And he's talking about Robert Blake being a jazz fan. I met him when I was in town, he said he's sorry he missed coming in to hear Ross Tompkins, at a place called Chadney's, or whatever. There are so few jazz saloons that make any sense these days, it's a lost art in its own way.

JB: Overseas you ran into a couple of fellows.

MR: Well we wound up on Iwo Jima and then Saipan-Tinian and then the war was still on and I was in Guam and they ran out of cots for the boys and we were sleeping on the ground in a tent on a G.I. blanket. And I was walking down the road and I ran into Joe Anderson, who was involved with Hamilton College. But at the time he was a Captain in the Marine Corps and he was a Provost Marshal of the Island. He was in charge of all of the native so-called police and had nothing to do with M.P.'s or military police. It had to do with the

police in charge of the natives, which couldn't have been that easy, they were all in a panic. They were dropping bombs on these guys. And I wound up staying with Joe. He had some of his native police build a tent with some wooden sides and a good canvas top and they built some two by fours, made beds out of them by using the inner tubes of B-29's that were no longer useful, and cutting them into about two inch strips and nailing it down, like crisscross on the two by fours with Coca Cola caps so they don't split, and it was the most comfortable bed I ever slept in in my life.

MR: Talk about improvising, ey?

JB: Oh yeah, I mean they were like jazz musicians. And that was a good rhythm section that built those beds, I'll tell you that. But anyway I was delighted to see Joe and we of course talked about Ernie Anderson, who was way back, way before Norman Granz from Jazz at the Philharmonic, he did all the NBC Eddie Condon T.V. shows when it was a great idea for a program but it needed people to own T.V. sets to see it, which is not the way it was. But he always had Hot Lips Page, Louis Armstrong, Jack Teagarden, Peanuts Hucko and George Wettling and myself, and it was some wonderful, wonderful music. And one of the things that makes you realize that there's a big difference in playing a program live and recording it, which companies never did often enough, and when you get in the studio that's a whole other sound.

MR: Well Ernie was very passionate about the music, wasn't he?

JB: Oh he was just terrific. Oh we hung out many, many, many years later and over the years and we were getting a theater in England together. I mean he turned out to be John Huston's right hand man, so I got to know John and hang out with Ernie and John at his castle in Ireland, near Galway. And anyway, so I stayed with Joe. They had an extra bed and there was a Marine major about my size and I would casually put his Marine major uniform on and go and have food at the Marine mess hall.

MR: Just casually.

JB: Instead of the kind of food we were getting, and they had the best food. In any case, there was a two-star general Marine who knew what I did, knew who I was, and didn't make any scene about it. He said it's great having you to dinner or something you know. And I played a couple of little cocktail parties for him in a Quonset hut and he was delighted. But anyway that goes back a ways. And I love Joe and in fact I played at Hamilton for Joe's going away party I believe it was.

MR: That's true.

JB: He was retiring and, well you can explain what Joe did at the college. He was a fundraiser I believe.

MR: Yes, and he very much — Communications and Development. He's a very important figure in the history of the college actually.

JB: Yeah well I'm sure he had a full professorship going at least.

MR: Did you ever have any inkling that you were NOT going to make a career in music? That you might do something else? Was there any question in your mind from the time you were a —

JB: No, I was really kind of stuck with it. There's a little pressure that goes on when you have a natural talent you know. Because you've got to live up to it and really produce and be creative when you're called upon. And there are many days, they talk about the right place at the right time, that doesn't happen as often as playing the gig you know? And as a matter of fact, you learn — I don't know how to put this — but you learn from your failures and you don't learn from your successes. You know?

MR: Yeah.

JB: And once you listen to a tape of an old 78 or a vinyl, you say now I could have done this better or that better, as a matter of fact I think it's interesting from a jazz point of view when I did the Louis Armstrong/Benny Goodman tour and I played with Louis, as Louis put it, we were walking in the rain one afternoon and he kind of looked over at me and he said "you're with the right Benny. You've got the right Benny on." Meaning in that kind of language, a Benny is a raincoat. And because the fact that I was with Benny's band after the war for a year, ten months or whatever it was, and I wrote a bunch of things for him, which we recorded, as a matter of fact Ernie — well I was delighted to be with Louis. It was a happy quintet. It was really fun.

MR: If you don't mind, I'm going to play something that dates back.
[audio interlude]

MR: I believe this was from 1953.

JB: What tune is it?

MR: This is "April in Portugal." So that goes back a ways.

JB: Well I'll tell you, Louis Armstrong, I like the fact that Wynton Marsalis talks about Louis all the time. And I appreciate that. It makes me listen to him a little more carefully. And Louis was the Messiah of our music, there's no two ways about it. And I don't know how to put this except Louis was like a great, great obstetrician who delivered a thousand kids but didn't have any of his own.

MR: I think that's a pretty good way to put it.

JB: That's it for sure. And what Louis did, I meant to mention, is that when I did the Armstrong Goodman concert, he always had a little Wollensack and he would record every one of our performances. And with all the static and just done off the cuff he'd

throw a mic on the floor someplace, backstage, and I asked him about it and he was writing his autobiography and playing the tapes the next night or whatever. And I always dressed in Lily's dressing room, he insisted on me doing that, and that was great for me. And I got a chance to really — you know I always loved Louis and we had a great rapport. And he was listening and I remember him listening to "The Saints Go Marching In" which is a finale. And one evening he played [scats] and he liked that phrase, so he kept it in from then on. So Louis was a stickler for listening to himself, and finding riffs that he liked, and avoiding the ones he thought were not as happy or didn't sound like him as much as he wanted it to. So he was truly a gifted artist, well we all know that.

MR: He would take something that was improvised and listen back to it and say hey, that's a great lick, I'm going to keep that as part of my —

JB: As part of the improvisation, right. When people talk about improvising music, you've got to know the tune to begin with you know. And after you've played it a number of times then it's fun to improvise on what you've originally played, and you find all kinds of better things to insert, and sometimes you don't so you go back to what you originally played, you know, you've got a cop out.

MR: You're learning from your mistakes as you said before.

JB: Exactly. You learn from that. And you don't ever learn from any success as much. But I must say that that changes that whole phraseology because if you had a good, successful concert, you do learn some riffs that you should repeat the next time around. Yeah, really, you learn from every move.

MR: Was Joe Glaser managing Louis?

JB: Oh yeah, at the time.

MR: And when you were with him too.

JB: In fact I mean Ernie did a lot of stuff for Joe, and when I was at the Embers I had Joe represent me. I hardly needed any representation to be playing nine weeks in a row with a quartet, and then later on I came back and played 26 weeks on 54th Street opposite El Morocco between Lex and Third, and we were always jammed with people. And there was another reason for it oddly, the economics of what one does keeps sneaking up on you. For example, there was a war tax after World War II which went on until the middle 50's someplace, about '53. So that went on for a good — the war was over in '45 in August, and that went on about seven, eight years. And there was a 20% tax on your bill if there was dancing or a stand-up comic, any dialogue, or any singing. And that would be considered a show then.

MR: You mean for the audience, if their bill was 20 bucks, there was a 20 percent tax on that as the war tax?

JB: Right. But there was no tax for instrumental groups. So if a guy showed up with a party of six or eight and racked up a tab for a C note or whatever, that twenty dollars took care of the waiter's tip and the cab ride. And so we did a lot of business, based on the fact that during the 26 week scene, we had Red Norvo's trio and my group. I was there for the whole 26 weeks and whatever you want to call it, I was considered the draw in the place. And then we had Teddy Wilson and a group, and actually that was a second floor to the Famous Door. No this is another time, this is way before that. But at the Embers we did have Roy Eldridge and the group, and Teddy Wilson and the group, and Red Norvo. So there was always a lot of great music and the wonderful thing I loved about my group with Buck Clayton, Milt Hinton and Jo Jones, he was a fantastic artist on the percussion, that if we didn't sound on the Tuesday night like we thought we should, I could go out and hock everything I owned and bet that the first set on Wednesday would be great. Because we all would sleep on it.

MR: No kidding.

JB: Of course. And in other words, Buck was such a great player, he would never let himself down. And there were times when things happened off the gig and at home and with some little kids running around to keep me awake when you should be getting some rest. You show up kind of beat up and that's what it's all about.

MR: Can you recall where you were the day that the war ended in Japan?

JB: That what?

MR: Where were you the day the war ended in Japan?

JB: Oh I was on Guam actually, and there were six or seven of us, Peter Lind Hayes and a few other guys who were involved in the Winged Victory show. Because when David Rose left Winged Victory I became musical director and I was conducting every night. When the show broke up we all wound up — well not all of us, but Peter Lind Hayes and Larry Adler, the harmonica player's brother Jerry Adler played harmonica, that was a great joy, but we wound up playing shows on aircraft carriers and all through the Mariana Islands. We were on Iwo Jima and it was an experience on Iwo Jima where we had papers to get to Saipan and being on the airfield two or three mornings in a row we couldn't get a ride. And we had our orders to be up at Saipan and we were having some chow and on the chow line, of all people to be there was Tyrone Power, who was the first looie I believe, and he was a flyer for a Marine cargo plane. And Peter Lind Hayes went up to him and said "you did a film with my wife Mary Hailey" and explained we were trying to get to Saipan. He said "that's where I'm headed if you don't mind sitting on the floor of the plane, we don't have any seats. He said "we'll be there." Well the next morning we were off with Power. And he was a perfect G.I. He had a couple of bottles of

scotch stashed in a duffel bag, and then of all guys I meet another Captain in the Marine Corps, was the guy that wrote "Route 66." You know the piano?

MR: Bobby Troup.

JB: Bobby Troup, right. And he was in charge of the black troops, which were the service group. They would straighten the planes out and load them up with whatever bombs. I remember being on Tinian when the Seabees left and the new group came in and took over their barracks and they had a wonderful mess hall fixed you, because the Seabees were doing all the building, and usually the outfit that was on an island longest would replace the Seabees as a camp. They would get their camp. This was a whole new outfit and they were a bunch of guys that that was the Colonel Tippett and the Elona Gay with the atomic bomb on it, and I've got to tell you, the G.I.'s with that outfit had no idea they had an atomic bomb. They were just simply told they had a very strong new bomb.

MR: They were just doing their job.

JB: Right.

MR: Was the end of the war a surprise or was it —

JB: Yeah it was quite a surprise because we were in the trans and flyers barracks and the M.P.'s drove up around three or four in the morning and said "hey guys, the war is over." And I had stashed a half a gallon of pure alcohol, which I got from an aircraft carrier, which you could mix with the little cans of grapefruit juice, and I mixed a drink for us. And the next move is I went over and started to choke an accordion player until I could kill him. It took four or five guys to get me off of him.

MR: You weren't fond of accordions?

JB: The guy who played the accordion on the show that Peter Lind Hayes put together, he was terrible. He couldn't get through "Melancholy Baby." I used to play the trumpet with one hand and the keyboard with my left hand to play the right chords, or something similar to the right chords.

MR: So you figured now that the war's over I can let this guy have it.

JB: Oh I've got to get rid of him. And sure enough, the war was back on. The emperor had reneged and so it was on for another 24 hours.

MR: Oh I didn't know that.

JB: Yeah, there were two — it was a false alarm and then the next night it was definitely over the next morning. I must say that Emperor Hirohito showed a great amount of whatever one would call it, unlike our President Clinton, he was a great leader, where don't forget, we were dealing with a dictatorship. It was a complete control on Radio Tokyo and the newspapers and so forth, and the media. And the emperor made a point of announcing to the Japanese people that they hadn't lost the war. An agreement was made with the allies

to treat the American G.I.'s like they wanted the Japanese soldiers to be treated in America and England and so forth. And I never did hear of whatever they call those traps, the rednecks from Oklahoma who were snagging little Japanese girls off the street you know and carrying them into corners and over to the railroad station where the coal was stashed in between set-ups, and carrying on. But there was never a rough up. As a matter of fact I did a 15 minute piano program, it was actually about 11 minutes with the dialogue, for the Army and they had the — how I found out about the emperor's move was through the Japanese Symphony Orchestra in the next studio at Radio Tokyo. And there were a couple of German French horn players who spoke English who actually went to school in America, and they're the ones, I said I was surprised at not hearing of any rough ups, and they explained that to me. And I got a lot of little post cards from different ships in the area and various G.I.'s asking for "Sweet Lorraine" and different tunes that they wanted to hear. It was a piano program. I was kind of the poor man's Uncle Don of Radio Tokyo at the time. And they actually gave me a jeep to get from an insurance building where we were all staying and I'm not very handy with tools, but I had to remove the carburetor when I parked the jeep otherwise it would be stolen.

MR: Oh no kidding.

JB: Oh yeah. But those were all — I could go on for nine days with the war experiences.

MR: Let me ask you about a couple of recordings. And if my information is correct, in 1936 you recorded with Billie Holiday.

JB: Yeah. "Billie's Blues," "Summertime," and, yeah, that became a classic 78.

MR: She was just — well where was her career at that point? Was she well known?

JB: No she was singing and carrying on in a saloon up in Harlem, as one of the young, good looking, black gals that the audience would dig. And Bernie Hanighen, who wrote "As Long as I Live" and a bunch of other good tunes with Johnny Mercer, was a big fan of Bunny Berigan's, Artie Shaw, myself included. And he's the one, he was an A&R man, a Repertoire Artists Director of Vocalion Records. And not John Hammond, but Bernie Hanighen was the first guy to record Billie Holiday. And I went down to Bernie's little pad in Greenwich Village. I had a whole stack of lead sheets from motion picture themes and various songs that the publishers were publishing at the time. That whole business has done a complete 180 turn, where The Beatles, I must give them credit for the fact that they published their own music. Because once they made a hit, no one else was going to make it. But that's not what went on in the music business at the time. They had the Jimmy Dorsey Band, Woody Herman, Benny Goodman, you know all of the different bands who were recording for various companies, and that was the reason to have a publisher but I must say, like all mortgage brokers and bankers, they had fifty percent of

the action. Whereas the lyricist got twenty-five percent and the composer got twenty-five percent.

MR: So the publishers were making out pretty well.

JB: Oh they were doing great. And they had some very low paying professional men running around delivering lead sheets.

MR: Trying to get the bands to record their songs.

JB: Yeah right. And then the publishers might come up with a case of scotch or some, you know, whatever you want to call it I guess, a payola, of that time.

MR: Did you find Billie Holiday different or a little difficult to play with because she often times would sing pretty far behind the beat?

JB: Yeah. No I didn't find that to be true at all. As a matter of fact she showed up at Bernie Hanighen's in a house coat with some egg stains on it, and not put together at all, and the minute she started to sing she looked very beautiful. It happens all the time of course. Like for example, when I was over in London, I was with Ernie Anderson getting a theater together and so forth, and a guy named Jerome White, Jerry White, he worked for the Rodgers and Hammerstein people, and he was a master sergeant like myself, as a stage manager for the Winged Victory. And when he found out I was in town he gave a party for me on the roof or whatever, of a big Marquette room, for the "Porgy & Bess" cast and whatever was going on at the time in London that he was in charge of. And I was just really delighted to see Cab Calloway and some wonderful guys, and Bill Bailey was the dancer with the show and he's Pearl Bailey's brother, who I had worked with at the Southland in Boston when I was with Bunny Berigan's band. And then Leontyne Price said she was going to sing, and she wanted to sing "Summertime" and I said "what's your range, what key do you do it in?" She said "the entire keyboard, play it in whatever key is comfortable for you." And there's another case of, the minute she laid her pipes on you, she looked beautiful. But she was so great, I never forgot it. She'd sing anything.

MR: Right. Well you did some singing yourself over the years.

JB: Yeah I sang, when I was with Bing I did a CD for the Norwegian Red Cross which you have a copy of, because Bing was signed with Polygram at the time and they had a deal arranged with United Artists so Bing said "why don't you do it?" And he could sing "Now You Has Jazz" to start the LP, and then he wrote a corny lyric to a public domain tune that he called "Sail Away From Norway" as a closing tune on that for the Norwegian Red Cross. So they took care of the boys, and I went to United Artists studio and did it. No big panic about it. And I was thrilled to have Johnny Smith playing — I love him, he's a great, great guy. And Jake Hanna and Milt. We just went ahead and did it.

MR: When did you first start to compose?

JB: Oh I don't know. Automatically playing the piano and improvising you're composing to start with. There was a situation that you might get a kick out of. Sinatra was the boy singer, they had Connie Haines with the group and the Pied Pipers. And I was really delighted to be with the Dorsey band, because you've got a nine foot coffin in front of you, and in any other band you're out there alone. It's not like being one of the trumpet players with a cohort on either side of you. And for instance when we were playing The Astor Roof back in 1940, if some exuberant female started pulling her dress up above her earlobes or whatever on the dance floor, and carrying on, I always had Sinatra sitting right by the piano to tap me on the shoulder and not look at the lead sheet, not look at the arrangement, you know, check that arrangement out. So I had that, that was fun for me. And I really loved being around the Pied Pipers and Jo Stafford and whatever. We were doing a program called Fame And Fortune. Oddly enough it was the Nature's Remedy company. And they made a laxative for older people and Tums you know, and here they were, they booked the Tommy Dorsey Band, which appealed to the youth. So that made a lot of sense.

MR: Brought to you by Nature's Laxative.

JB: Huh?

MR: Oh that's funny.

JB: Yeah. And every week we'd get a stack of tunes because the winning tune would be the closing number of the half hour show, and it would always be done with the Pied Pipers and Connie Haines and Sinatra, and they'd make a big production out of it. And you couldn't look for any musical talent there except if you can run into a lyric that made any sense at all, Sy Oliver and Alex Stordahl and Paul Weston, we had three great arrangers, and myself, could sketch out a production number and make it sound good. And Tommy Dorsey in his most generous fashion, as we call him, the "laughing Irishman," the big prize on the program was a hundred dollar war bond, or a one hundred dollar government bond at the time, and that the Tommy Dorsey, BMI Publishing Company would be publishing the song that was chosen.

MR: How did they decide who the winner was?

JB: Well it was just by mail that came in on the tunes, and reaction from people, I guess you might call it a poll taken in some sense. Yeah, that's how they decided on it. And we got out to the west coast and opened the Hollywood Palladium, the Dorsey band did, and somehow or other Tommy's music company didn't forward the music for the Fame and Fortune Program. This was like a Wednesday, and the program was Thursday, or maybe it was a Tuesday and a Wednesday. We were at the L.A. Paramount. I think it was called the Philharmonic at the time, and doing a film and a swing band stage show in between

each film. And we were looking for a tune and it hadn't arrived, and I had written a tune, I had written a couple of tunes for the Pied Pipers because they had very few arrangements for the Pipers with the band. And Tommy was never there for the first set. And he'd leave for the last set. He'd come in and do a set for dancing and then a show and so forth. And Bunny Berigan was with the band when I joined Tommy's band, and Bunny would always call "Oh Look at Me Now" and Sinatra would do "How Do You Do Without Me" which are two tunes I had written at the time for them, during the first set. And people would dance by and ask Tommy for "Oh Look at Me Now," and he said "we don't have that," because he had no idea we had it. And so Sy or Alex Stordahl said "why don't we use one of Joe's tunes and not put my name on it, because if you were part of the band you weren't allowed to submit a tune for a winner on the program and so forth. Same old. And so they just put Johnny DeVries name on it. And later on when all the other people recorded it they had my name on the record. And I managed to get it away from Tommy to put in ASCAP when I joined ASCAP. And I was writing a whole lot of stuff. I started to write a show with DeVries and I was very happy writing with him. But anyway, that got the most mail. So we recorded it with another tune. Tommy made it the B side to keep the noise down. And that turned out to be a standard hit as it turns out. And what happened is I wrote it for the Pipers and it was easy enough to put Sinatra into it, and Connie Haines. And so that became an ad lib. We did it the very same night. We chose it that afternoon and that night we did the Fame and Fortune program and Sy Oliver and Alex Stordahl with some strips of music, five lines to change a riff here and there, in order to match up all the singers doing it and so forth, and make a production out of it. And that's how that happened. And actually I started to tell you during the war when I was a band leader at Douglas I was in town and I ran into Frank at the Brown Derby and he invited me back to the Huntington Hartford Theater where they were doing the Old Gold program. And he said Jesus, a lot of cats who were in Tommy's band are with the studio band. They'd love to hang out with ya. And also the fact that you couldn't get a drink if you were in uniform until 5 P.M., and this was around lunch time. He said "I've got a bar set up in my dressing room, you can carry on." And he said "have you been writing any tunes?" And I said "well some marches and so forth." And I did "Hot Time in the Town of Berlin." He said I can't record it because we can't use musicians, but Bing has a retroactive deal with the union, and I know he's recording next week, and so he said his company, Frank's company, would publish it and get it to Bing. And then later on I talked to Bing and Bing said "I saw your name on it, Master Sergeant Joe Bushkin, PFC Johnny DeVries." He said "I knew you could use a few extra bucks with the kind of loot you were getting from the government from that band, and so I was going

to record it. I didn't even know what it went like. And it turned out to be a hit as things would happen.

MR: You said he had some kind of deal with the union? He could record —

JB: With musicians. And so he and the Andrews Sisters and the band, Vic Schoen was the arranger then from the Andrews Sisters, and he could use musicians because Bing owned half of Decca. So he was able to say you've got half of the royalty on any of the records for the Musician's Pension Fund. That's what it was all about. And the other companies were backing off, because they kept insisting, look we only pay our men $30 for a three hour session and we're not paying any royalty to you, so they'd try to beat the rap.

MR: I guess that was a good thing in the end, but there was a lot of music that was lost during those two years that never got on wax.

JB: Yeah. Like there were a lot of three point baskets not thrown by the NBA with their strike.

MR: That's true.

JB: It's the same old — it will go on forever.

MR: Good analogy.

JB: I'm not concerned about that. I have no feeling about longevity, because everything seems to be the same anyway.

MR: You witnessed some of the changes in the segregation between the blacks and whites in music.

JB: Well let's see. In Benny's band as you know, Lionel Hampton and I don't know — in 1951 I opened the Embers, I had Buck Clayton — oddly enough I had three black guys with me. Milt Hinton, Buck Clayton and Jo Jones. Later on Johnny Smith. Buck had to do some stuff with Count Basie again and Johnny Smith came in and played with us so we were split equally, two white and two colored. And as a young kid, or going to school, there was always deep segregation. And as a matter of fact, a thing that Milt Hinton was telling me was that he was the first concert bassist with the Northwestern Symphony Orchestra, and the Chicago Symphony needed bass players. And he was not invited to audition, because there were no blacks in symphony orchestras at that point. It's hard to believe but that's what's happening. And it's going to take another hundred years or two for it to straighten itself out I'm sure.

MR: You were involved in one of Bing Crosby's last recording too, weren't you? It was around '76 or so?

JB: Yeah back in '77 actually when we did the Norwegian —

MR: That was one of the last ones.

JB: Yeah, under my label, under my name, whatever. And Bing sang "Now You Has Jazz" and "Sail Away from Norway," and that's really the last commercial record he ever did. As a matter of fact when you talk about the segregation of black musicians or white musicians back then, it didn't seem to matter if a guy was blue, black, yellow or green if he sounded great, played like Louis Armstrong, you could be whiter than white.

MR: I have another selection here that goes back a ways. It's really a different style. I'm curious about why this particular kind of music was being done at the time. I think you'll probably recognize this.

[audio interlude -- very loud]

JB: Yeah well that's Ray Conniff who was in Bunny Berigan's band, we were together, and he did some choral records for Columbia, for Mitch Miller, and they seemed to catch on and Capitol wanted me to use a choral group with the piano. That's how that came about.

MR: And this was around what year? Do you remember? I have the record here.

JB: Yeah, around '55, '54, '55.

MR: Yeah. There seemed to be a whole kind of, a lot of instrumental music popular even into the 50's.

JB: Oh absolutely. And the first LP I did for Capitol, it was a wonderful man, his name was Abe Berman, and he represented Harold Arlen, Johnny Mercer, Vince Youmans — I could go on almost forever, and he was a wonderful, wonderful old guy. And he knew I was at the Embers and doing well, and I made some records for Columbia with a quartet, you probably know about those records. And I was talking to Abe about, well he sold Capitol Records for Johnny Mercer and Buddy DeSilva, to EMI, the Electric Music Industries in London. And obviously being the attorney making the deal, he knew their kind of thinking. And back then, as you know, Art Tatum or Teddy Wilson, it didn't matter who it was, a jazz recording, if it sold 25,000 LP's it was like a July 4th celebration. And I just talked to Abe about it. I said "the idea is to get a wider public and play some ballads" or whatever. So he had an idea and he talked to me and he talked to the company and the deal he got for me was that I would record a mood album with piano and I was going to use strings and orchestra. And if I sold 50,000 within six months, they would then be obligated to pick up a three year contract of three LP's a year, all right, and I'd be allowed to use the same amount of men that I paid for on the first LP. So I was able to use all kinds of different instrumentation later on with Ken Hopkins, we worked on a "Blue Angels" LP with eight trombones, you know, for stereo, with four on each speaker, which an engineer screwed up by putting it all together of course. But that's the way the thinking was at the time. But what I did was after doing the LP I was in the position to pay for it at the time and also I was in a position to go off on the road. I was

staying in Palm Springs at the time with the family, and I started a tour up in Boston in February in the middle of a snow storm. And back in those days there was a whole different approach to marketing recordings. Every company had their own professional manager in every major city, including Hartford and New Haven etcetera, and that manager would hire two or three salesmen to go around with the recordings and go to the department stores and little record shops or gramaphone shops or whatever, and they'd get some action for you. And the way to get that going was simply to show up and do a disc jockey tour in each town. So I never did go to bed to speak of for about 20 cities in a row, oh I think it was 26. And by the time I got to Chicago from Boston, I went by Marshall Field and wanted to get a few LP's, and they said "we have orders for about a dozen of them." They didn't know who I was, and "we can put you on a waiting list." I couldn't understand that and I called Abe Berman. And as it turned out, Mike Maitland, who later went with Reprise and all that, he was supposed to, he and a chap named Bud Frazier, were in charge of making sure that there were enough LP's that were going to be sold. And the deal that Abe Berman had organized for me was that I would sell 50,000 in six months. And they only pressed 25,000. So that, so Abe called Glen Wallichs who was in charge of, he had been in charge when Mercer owned it and Abe certainly knew him, and he said that doesn't fly. And they had Columbia and Decca and every other company pressing my LP to get it out real quick, so that we sold 300,000 of the LP's in the first year. Then of course they picked up the contract and I went on and did other mood albums. And of course the company, they had an A&R man who used to be a trombonist, Andy Winslow with Guy Lombardo's band, that was a big help to me, and whenever the orchestra overshadowed the piano, fortunately my wife Frannie was in the control booth and let me know that. So we straightened that out. Anyway then I did "Skylight Rhapsody" and the third LP of mood albums with a 45, 50 piece band like the first one was a thing called "A Fellow Needs a Girl." And the cover of that was done by a good friend of ours, Dickie Avedon, the great photographer. It's the only album cover that he'd ever done, or ever did since. So that's a kick. Anyway and then trying to find all the standards that I had on the first LP got a little difficult. By the third LP there were no more standards to look for.

MR: I see. So you were like scraping for material.

JB: Yeah. It didn't make any sense. And that's when I switched over to doing "Night Sound," "Blue Angel," "I Get a Kick out of Porter," because I had Cole Porter's music to work with. And the Irving Berlin album. That was based on his 50th year as a composer. And I used "I Love A Piano" as a theme song, which he wrote in 1917, the year after I was born, and I got to know Irving. I did the Bell Telephone Hour when they did an Irving

Berlin special and he was there and I was delighted to hang out with him. And I went over and saw him, I only lived a couple of blocks from Beekman Place where Berlin lived. We were on Sutton. And I went over and had some coffee with him and to discuss it. And I thought of doing a 50th, because you can get almost 30 minutes on an LP side. And even the ballad would not take more than a minute, that's why usually back in those days the single records always were two and a half minutes or three minutes. And so I figured you could do 25 on each side, that would be his 50th anniversary. And the way to do it obviously, which Berlin came up with, I wanted to try and do like an orchestral overture, and it got a little complicated, in sketching it. And he said "why don't you just do it like a Tommy Dorsey arrangement" or Les Brown or whatever, swing bands. He said you could whistle that one out, you can put that together. So we did on the Berlin album, it was "Bushkin Spotlights Berlin" they changed it to "Irving Berlin Piano Party" or something on the CD. But anyway we just did it like a medley. A bunch of ballads and then an uptempo thing, and it was all connected. And he got a big charge out of that, he really did. In fact he was like — Irving Berlin, you see all of the composers, Jimmy VanHeusen, Irving Berlin, Richard Rodgers, Cole Porter — I can go on and on with it — were all great song pluggers. And when you recorded their music, they loved you for it, of course.

MR: He's not the guy that composed everything in one key, is he?

JB: Yeah. He composed everything on the black keys. I couldn't play on the black keys, but that's the way he played. He was self taught and he had it covered. He was wonderful.

MR: Let me just ask you a couple, maybe a quick comment about some of the other — that long, long list of people you've worked with. What kind of boss was Tommy Dorsey?

JB: Oh Tommy was fine in this sense. If you could improvise, he'd never give you any heat. Like Don Lodice, Buddy Rich, Bunny Berigan, myself, Ziggy. He'd always pick on the good technical players, of which he was the best. Tommy had the most tremendous trombone technique, and breathing and so forth. Sinatra always talks about him, learned how to breathe, long phrases based on Tommy Dorsey's method of doing it. But he was very difficult with any — like the lead saxophone player, lead trumpet player. And I remember one time when we were doing the Fame and Fortune program and we were in New York playing, and I think we were at the Astor Roof as a matter of fact, and we went to NBC and recorded the Fame and Fortune show. And the sponsor of the program was there and something happened with a DS. In musical terms it's called del signa, it's the Italian phrase for go back to the sign. So when you have a del signa, which is DS a circle with a cross in it and a couple of dots, at a certain barline, say bar one or two, and instead of writing a first and second ending, because if you wanted that section repeated

you just put a DS sign where you wanted it to go back. Anyway a couple of guys in the band didn't pay any attention to the DS sign and it sounded strange. And Tommy wanted to make good with the sponsor being there. He kind of had a little apple pie on his face. And Steve Lipkins, who is a wonderful lead trumpet player with us, along with Chuck Peterson and other guys — but he would pick on Steve. And he said "Lipkins" and Steve never was dialogue free. He came from a — his dad was an anti-trust lawyer, was one of those very, very high end.

MR: Straight laced kind of guys?

JB: Yeah very strict and so forth. And Steven had that built in. And Steve stood up and Tommy said "what does DS mean?" And Steve said "Dorsey Stinks." That broke the band up of course, we loved him for it. I thought Tommy would get mad at him but he thought it was very special.

MR: Oh yeah?

JB: Yeah. Tommy was okay. And Tommy loved playing jazz on the trumpet and when I was with the band Bunny Berigan would actually toss his trumpet clear from the trumpet section over to the piano during "Loosers Weepers" when Tommy was playing some trumpet solo, and then I would follow that. It was a Blues in B flat. And the guys in the band loved the idea that I would out-improvise them every time. So he never gave me any heat.

MR: Oh great. How about Eddie Condon?

JB: Oh I loved Eddie, Eddie was a barrel house, he was one of the guys in the band. The thing about Tommy Dorsey and Benny Goodman and Bunny Berigan especially, they were instrumentalists, like we were. It wasn't like Paul Whiteman or someone up there with a fiddle under his arm who didn't play. And that makes a big difference.

MR: They weren't just leaders, they were players too.

JB: They were players. That was very important.

MR: What's your musical taste these days? What do you like to listen to?

JB: I don't really listen to very much music. I still listen to Louis Armstrong, a lot of his tapes. And I have a big problem with understanding the lyrics of a lot of the Rock 'n Roll people, and I like a lot of them. I get a kick out of the Gospel sound, I really like that. And I don't know, at my age and four grown up kids later and three grandchildren, I'm kind of busy hanging with my Louis Armstrong.

MR: Right. Well you can't go wrong with that, that's for sure.

JB: No. No way. I wrote a couple of things for the Benny Goodman band, Ernie Anderson, who became entertainment direction for *Esquire* got Johnny DeVries and I to write a tune for the 1947 year end issue. And I wrote "The Man Here Plays Fine Piano" for that, and

Benny Goodman's band recorded it. And I forget the name of the gal who was singing with us at the time sang it. I put that together. And then there was a sponsor — well when I joined Benny's band I was with the NBC Orchestra with Bobby Hackett and a bunch of guys, and Benny was in town, and I always wanted to play with Benny. I knew from the time I was 12, 13 years old actually, because I played in a high school band with his brother Irving, who was a good trumpet player. I got to know Harry Goodman, was in my Army band, I mean I'm totally involved with that family. And the sponsor was there with a very beautiful as I recall, Danish wife. Well it was a program called "Concert Under the Stars," and Benny was just delighted about me being with the NBC band because he didn't have to pay me for the program, NBC was paying me. That was a way to save a few bucks. And I wrote a couple of arrangements for him so I can pick up an extra seventy-five or a C note, each arrangement, every week. And I was rehearsing "Don't Blame Me" I remember that tune, rehearsing them. And I wrote an intro like Bunny Berigan's "I Can't Get Started" for him and then realized that Benny didn't read guitar changes, for the chord changes, to improvise on the changes.

MR: Benny didn't?

JB: No. He didn't. He could read all the notes, classically written, but not the guitar changes, which is...

MR: Oh no kidding?

JB: Well that's a jazz manner of knowing chord changes. Simplifies it. But would you excuse me for a minute?

MR: Sure. We're just about done too.

[pause]

MR: I'll just wrap you up and you'll be done.

JB: I'll just finish the story about the sponsor with Benny.

MR: Right, and then I'll just thank you and we can be on our way.

JB: That's cool.

Tim: We'll be done in a couple of seconds and you'll be all set.

MR: Yeah. Let's just wrap this up. Are we rolling?

JB: I'll just continue on. Well being with NBC and doing the Concert of the Stars, that's when I joined Benny's band. When that program was over in New York, it was the summertime apparently, then when we went to the west coast, and this is something that bothered Benny a lot, it was called the Victor Borge program. It was for Mobil gas and Socony. And the reason for it, no one knew who Victor Borge was. They knew who Benny Goodman's band was. But it turns out that the sponsor was married to a very, very beautiful Danish lady, and they came down to say hello to Benny. They wanted to

meet him. And you know, Benny and his graceful manner didn't bother to introduce me, I was standing right there scribbling out his chord changes on his part. And the sponsor's wife said "I don't understand if this program is called 'Concert of the Stars' in Denmark, at a park concert, they always start with a march." And that kind of confused Benny slightly. And he just turned around and said "Joe, bring a couple marches in next week." You know that was the end of that. So I brought in Sousa's "Under the Double Eagle" [scats] and I did a jazz arrangement of that and a jazz arrangement of a tune called "Colonel Bogey," which later on became a big hit on the "Bridge Over the River Kwai." And Benny in his stubborn manner, you know if you say yes, he'd have to say no, there was no other way, he wouldn't record "Colonel Bogie." And the guys in the band loved playing "Colonel Bogey" because it swung more. You know it had a better swing sound. Anyway Benny called "Under the Double Eagle" that I did, he called it "Benji's Bauble," one of his daughter's names, and put his name on it and my name, so I got a little royalty out of that. In any case that's the end of that story.

MR: Right. Well you know you've had just the longest, most productive career, and it's been a great pleasure talking to you.

JB: Okay, thank you, Monk.

MR: Out here in Los Angeles. So I appreciate your time, and bringing these CD's for me to listen to back at the college.

JB: Sure.

MR: Well I most appreciate it. I'm sure our students will get a lot out of —

JB: Say hello to all the jazz fans at Hamilton. Because they were just the greatest. And I've got Joe Anderson's Vermont phone number, that's where he's living these days.

MR: Yes he is.

JB: And I've got his phone number, I've got to give him a call and tell him we were together.

MR: In fact I think I'll send him a copy of this video.

JB: Oh he'd love to have it, I'm sure.

MR: And you'll get one too.

JB: Okay Monk, all the best.